Mariam said when they showed her my photograph she could not recognise me.

'They told me your name and asked me to utter it, but I couldn't get it right. They made me try many times, but your name was still a tongue-twister for me. So one of them wrote your name on a paper, in big letters and held it above the video camera. I was asked to read out from the paper.'

This, Mariam had told CBI earlier. To verify her statement, CBI officers watched the video several times and found that when Mariam was to say my name her eyes hovered above the camera lens. This statement and a similar one by Fauziyya were to be rejected by the CBI and the courts later.

Mariam was weeping as she narrated her ordeal at the hands of the Kerala police and later the IB officials. In between she kept saying 'sorry'. For the first time, I felt sad for the woman.

A woman constable, who was listening to our conversation, could not contain her curiosity.

'So, this spy case is not real?

'The case is real, and that's why you are taking me to a court now,' I said. 'But the theory of spying is imagination.'

'Tell me in simple terms, sir. Did you or did you not give rocket secrets to Pakistan?'

'No.'

She felt relieved with the piece of information.

There was another constable, a young man, who wanted to sit next to me, both the times we were taken to the court. He, unlike the woman constable, had no confusion over the ISRO spy case.

'I have been following this case from the day Mariam Rasheeda was arrested,' he said. 'And every passing day I was getting increasingly convinced that it is a fake case.'

During the second outing for remand extension, I asked about his background. He said he was a postgraduate in arts, but had to hide his MA degree to get the job of a constable since he was overqualified for the job.

Visiting me in the jail, my son Sankar told me that we too should move for bail through a big name lawyer, preferably M N Sukumaran Nair. He